contributions (NDCs), which outline their emissions targets and strategies for achieving them. While enforcement relies largely on transparency and public accountability, NDCs are publicly available, allowing NGOs, states, and citizens to apply pressure on leaders who fail to meet their commitments (Bodle, Donat, and Duwe 2016; Tingley and Tomz 2022; Casler, Clark, and Zucker 2024). Scientific expertise plays a crucial role in shaping these targets, as accurate data on emissions, mitigation strategies, and progress are vital for achieving the agreement's ambitious goals.

Under President Obama, the United States pledged to reduce emissions by 26 to 28 percent below 2005 levels by 2025, with a focus on expanding renewable energy and improving energy efficiency. However, Donald Trump, upon assuming office in 2017, announced his intention to withdraw the United States from the Paris Agreement, framing the decision as a reassertion of US sovereignty (Pavone 2018). Trump dismissed climate science as a "hoax" and often mocked the concept of global warming, using cold weather events to undermine the scientific consensus on climate change.[82] He criticized the Paris Agreement as unfair to the United States, claiming it disproportionately advantaged other nations while imposing unnecessary costs on American businesses. Trump's rhetoric, such as calling the agreement a "total con job"[83] and alleging that it was designed by China to harm US competitiveness,[84] resonated with his populist base and bolstered his anti-globalist narrative.

The US withdrawal dealt a significant blow to the Paris Agreement, as the country is both a major emitter and a global leader whose participation is critical to the pact's legitimacy. Recognizing this, world leaders and diplomats worked tirelessly to persuade Trump to remain in the agreement. At the 2017 G7 meeting, leaders from France, Japan, Canada, Italy, and the UK lobbied Trump intensively,[85] while French president Emmanuel Macron went so far as to host Trump in Paris in 2018, attempting to win him over with flattery.[86] These diplomatic efforts, conducted largely behind closed doors to sideline Trump's populist base, ultimately failed, as Trump had made withdrawal a highly visible campaign promise that he could not abandon without losing credibility among his supporters.

With Trump unyielding, the remaining signatories decided to move forward without the United States, sidelining his administration and focusing on preserving the agreement. UNFCCC officials and world leaders